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AI



What is Mistral AI?
Everything to know
about the OpenAI
competitor

Mistral

Mistral AI, the French company behind AI assistant Le Chat and several foundational models, is officially regarded as one of [France's most promising tech startups](#) and is [arguably the only European company that could compete with OpenAI](#). But compared to its \$6 billion valuation, its global market share is still relatively low.

However, the recent launch of its chat assistant on mobile app stores was met with some hype, particularly in its home country. “Go and download Le Chat, which is made by Mistral, rather than ChatGPT by OpenAI — or something else,” French president Emmanuel Macron said [in a TV interview](#) ahead of the AI Action Summit in Paris in February 2025.

While this wave of attention may be encouraging, Mistral AI still faces challenges in competing with the likes of OpenAI — and in doing so while keeping up with its self-definition as “the world’s greenest and leading independent AI lab.”

What is Mistral AI?

Mistral AI has raised significant amounts of funding since its creation in 2023 with the ambition to “put frontier AI in the hands of everyone.” While this isn’t a direct jab at OpenAI, the slogan is meant to highlight the company’s advocacy for openness in AI.

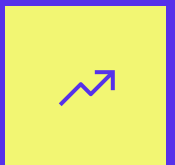
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Its alternative to ChatGPT, chat assistant Le Chat, is now also [available on iOS and Android](#). It reached [1 million downloads](#) in the two weeks following its mobile release, even grabbing France’s top spot for free downloads on the iOS App Store.

In July 2025, Mistral AI updated Le Chat with [new features that bring it closer to rival full-stack AI chatbots](#): a new “deep research” mode, native multilingual reasoning, and advanced image editing. This update also includes the addition of Projects, which lets users group chats, documents, and ideas into focused spaces.

This comes in addition to Mistral AI’s suite of models, which includes:

- Lina Khan points to Figma IPO as vindication of M&A scrutiny
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines

TC

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- [Mistral Large 2](#), the primary large language model replacing [Mistral Large](#).
- [Pixtral Large](#), [unveiled in 2024](#) as a new addition to the [Pixtral family of multimodal models](#).

- [Magistral](#), its first family of reasoning models, launched in June 2025.
- [Mistral Medium 3](#), released in May 2025 with the promise of providing efficiency without compromising performance, and best for coding and STEM tasks.
- [Voxtral](#), Mistral's first open source AI audio model, released in July 2025.
- [Devstral](#), an AI model designed for coding and openly available under an Apache 2.0 license, meaning it can be used commercially without restriction.
 - In July 2025, Mistral AI [introduced Devstral Medium](#), as well as an upgrade to Devstral Small, under a collaboration between Mistral AI and [All Hands AI](#) that puts emphasis on agentic coding capabilities.
 - Devstral is also one of the four models powering [coding assistant Mistral Code](#).
- [Codestral](#), an earlier generative AI model for code, but whose license banned commercial applications.
- "Les Ministraux," a family of models [optimized for edge devices](#) such as phones.
- Mistral Saba, [focused on Arabic language](#).

In March 2025, the company [introduced Mistral OCR](#), an optical character recognition (OCR) API that can turn any PDF into a text file to make it easier for AI models to ingest.

In May 2025, it released the [Mistral Agents API](#) to ["empower enterprises to use AI in more practical and impactful ways,"](#) according to its Head of Developer Relations, Sophia Yang.

In June 2025, Mistral AI also released a vibe coding client, [Mistral Code](#), to compete with incumbents like Windsurf, AnySphere's Cursor, and GitHub Copilot.

Who are Mistral AI's founders?

Mistral AI's three founders share a background in AI research at major U.S. tech companies with significant operations in Paris. CEO Arthur Mensch used to work at Google's DeepMind, while CTO Timothée Lacroix and chief scientist officer Guillaume Lample are former Meta staffers.

Co-founding advisers also include [Jean-Charles Samuelian-Werve](#) (also a board member) and Charles Gorintin from health insurance startup Alan, as well as former digital minister Cédric O, which has caused [persistent controversy](#) due to his previous role.

Are Mistral AI's models open source?

[Not all of them](#). Mistral AI differentiates its premier models, whose [weights](#) are not available for commercial purposes, from its free models, for which it provides weight access under the Apache 2.0 license.

Free models include research models such as Mistral NeMo, which was built in collaboration with Nvidia that the startup [open sourced](#) in July 2024.

How does Mistral AI make money?

While many of Mistral AI's offerings are free or [now have free tiers](#), Mistral AI plans to drive some

revenue from Le Chat's paid tiers. Introduced in February 2025, Le Chat's Pro plan is priced at \$14.99 a month.

On the purely B2B side, Mistral AI monetizes its premier models through APIs with usage-based pricing. Enterprises can also license these models, and the company likely also generates a significant share of its revenue from its strategic partnerships, some of which it highlighted [during the Paris AI Summit](#).

Overall, however, Mistral AI's revenue is reportedly still in the eight-digit range, according to multiple sources.

What partnerships has Mistral AI closed?

In 2024, Mistral AI entered a deal with Microsoft that included a strategic partnership for distributing its AI models through Microsoft's Azure platform and a €15 million investment. The U.K.'s Competition and Markets Authority (CMA) [swiftly concluded](#) that the deal didn't qualify for investigation due to its small size. However, it also sparked some [criticism](#) in the EU.

In January 2025, Mistral AI [signed a deal with press agency Agence France-Presse](#) (AFP) to let Chat query the AFP's entire text archive dating back to 1983.

Mistral AI also secured strategic partnerships with France's [army](#) and [job agency](#), [Luxembourg](#), [shipping giant CMA](#), German defense tech startup [Helsing](#), [IBM](#), [Orange](#), and [Stellantis](#).

In May 2025, Mistral AI announced it would participate in the creation of [an AI Campus in the Paris region](#), as part of a joint venture with UAE-

investment firm MGX, NVIDIA, and France's state-owned investment bank [Bpifrance](#).

In June 2025, it was announced that beginning in 2026, Mistral will launch a European platform dedicated to AI and powered by Nvidia processors, [Mistral Compute](#). The initiative was [hailed as 'historic' by Macron](#), who shared the stage with Mensch and Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang at the VivaTech conference shortly after the announcement.

In July 2025, it announced [AI for Citizens](#), “a collaborative initiative to help States and public institutions strategically harness AI for their people by transforming public services, catalyzing innovation, and ensuring competitiveness.”

How much funding has Mistral AI raised to date?

As of February 2025, Mistral AI raised around €1 billion in capital to date, approximately \$1.04 billion at the current exchange rate. This includes some debt financing, as well as several equity financing rounds raised in close succession.

In June 2023, and before it even released its first models, Mistral AI raised a [record \\$112 million seed round](#) led by Lightspeed Venture Partners. Sources at the time said the seed round — [Europe's largest ever](#) — valued the then-one-month-old startup at \$260 million.

Other investors in this seed round included Bpifrance, Eric Schmidt, Exor Ventures, First Minute Capital, Headline, JCDecaux Holding, La Famiglia, LocalGlobe, Motier Ventures, Rodolphe Saadé, Sofina, and Xavier Niel.

Only six months later, it closed [a Series A of €385 million](#) (\$415 million at the time), at a reported valuation of \$2 billion. The round was led by Andreessen Horowitz (a16z), with participation from existing backer Lightspeed, as well as BNP Paribas, CMA-CGM, Conviction, Elad Gil, General Catalyst, and Salesforce.

The [\\$16.3 million convertible investment](#) that Microsoft made in Mistral AI as part of their partnership announced in February 2024 was presented as a Series A extension, implying an unchanged valuation.

In June 2024, Mistral AI then raised [€600 million in a mix of equity and debt](#) (around \$640 million at the exchange rate at the time). The [long-rumored round](#) was led by General Catalyst at a \$6 billion valuation, with notable investors, including Cisco, IBM, Nvidia, Samsung Venture Investment Corporation, and others.

Mistral AI is now [reportedly in talks to raise \\$1 billion](#) in equity from investors including Abu Dhabi's MGX fund, as well as hundreds of millions of euros in debt.

How is Mistral AI approaching AI regulation?

Mensch was part of a group of European CEOs who [signed an open letter](#) in July 2025 urging Brussels to [‘stop the clock’](#) for two years before key obligations of the EU Artificial Intelligence Act enter into force. The European Commission is [sticking to its original timeline](#).

What could a Mistral AI exit look like?

Mistral is “not for sale,” Mensch said in January 2025 at the World Economic Forum in Davos. “Of course, [an IPO is] the plan.”

This makes sense, given how much the startup has raised so far: Even a large sale may not provide high enough multiples for its investors, not to mention sovereignty concerns depending on the acquirer.

However, the only way to definitely squash persistent acquisition rumors — lately naming Apple — is to scale its revenue to levels that could

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Paris-based AI startup Mistral AI raises \$640M

Romain Dillet — 5:43 AM PDT · June 11, 2024



Mistral AI has closed its much-rumored Series B funding round, raising **€600 million** (around \$640 million at today's exchange rate) in a mix of equity and debt. General Catalyst led the round. As TechCrunch previously reported, the startup is now valued at \$6 billion following this funding round.

As a reminder, Mistral AI is a relatively new entrant in the artificial intelligence space. The company raised a massive **\$112 million seed round** about a year ago to set up a European rival to OpenAI, Anthropic and other AI giants.

Co-founded by alumni from Meta and Google's DeepMind, the company is working on foundational models with the aim to rival the best performing models today, such as OpenAI's GPT-4o, Anthropic's Claude 3 and Meta's Llama 3.

IMAGE CREDITS:
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Mistral AI has also released pre-trained and fine-tuned models under an open source license with open weights. For instance, Mistral 7B, Mistral 8x7B and Mistral 8x22B were released under the Apache 2.0 license, an open source license that has no restrictions on use or reproduction beyond attribution.

Mistral AI’s most advanced models, such as [Mistral Large](#), are proprietary models designed to be repackaged as API-first products. [Codestral](#), the company’s first generative AI model for code, has a restrictive license, as its outputs can’t be used for commercial activities.

Companies can use Mistral Large through an API that they’ll have to pay for according to how much they use it. The company also offers a chat assistant called Le Chat that is currently free to use. The company also has distribution partnerships with cloud providers, such as Microsoft Azure — Microsoft is also a minor shareholder in Mistral AI.

“I am delighted to see new and existing investors renew their confidence in our business and provide new support for its expansion. This new round puts us in a unique position to push the frontier of AI and bring state-of-the-art technology to everyone’s hands,” Mistral AI co-founder and CEO, Arthur Mensch, said in a statement. “It guarantees the company’s continued independence, which remains fully under the founders’ control.”

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General Catalyst, which led the Series B round, was an existing investor in the startup. According to the [Financial Times](#), Mistral AI raised €468 million in equity and €132 million in debt (around \$500 million and \$140 million, respectively). The long, long list of investors includes Lightspeed Venture Partners, Andreessen Horowitz, Nvidia, Samsung Venture Investment Corporation, and Salesforce Ventures.

Other investors include Belfius, Bertelsmann Investment, BNP Paribas, Bpifrance (through its Digital Venture fund), Cisco, Eurazeo, Headline, Hanwha Asset Management's venture fund, IBM, Korelya Capital, Latitude, Millennium New Horizons, Sanabil Investments, ServiceNow and SV Angel.

Mistral AI's work over the past 18 months has been impressive when it comes to releasing foundational models. Now let's see if it can attract corporate customers to turn this engineering work into revenue.

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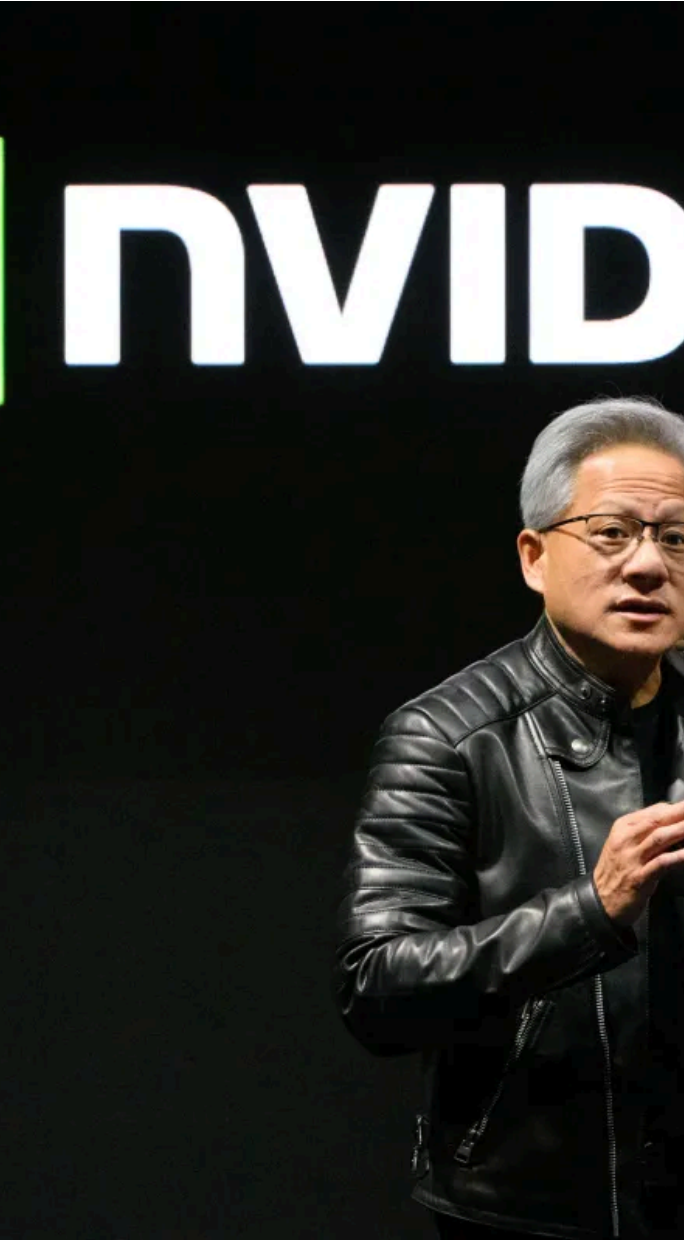
Romain Dillet

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Romain Dillet was a Senior Reporter at TechCrunch until April 2025. He has written over 3,500 articles on technolo...

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A large image featuring the Nvidia logo in white on a black background. In the foreground, Jensen Huang, CEO of Nvidia, is shown from the chest up, wearing a black leather jacket and glasses, gesturing with his hands as if speaking.

AI



Nvidia's AI empire: A look at its top startup investments

Marina Temkin — 3:12 AM PDT · June 19, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS:

AKIO KON/BLOOMBERG / GETTY IMAGES

No company has capitalized on the AI revolution more dramatically than Nvidia. Its revenue, profitability, and cash reserves have skyrocketed since the introduction of ChatGPT over two years

Latest in AI

ago — and the many competitive generative AI services that have launched since. And its stock price soared.

During that period, the world’s leading high-performance GPU maker has used its ballooning fortunes to significantly increase investments in all sorts of startups but particularly in AI startups.

The chip giant ramped up its venture capital activity in 2024, participating in 49 funding rounds for AI companies, a sharp increase from 34 in 2023, according to PitchBook data. It’s a dramatic surge in investment compared to the previous four years combined, during which Nvidia funded only 38 AI deals. Note that these investments exclude those made by its formal corporate VC fund, NVentures, which also significantly ramped up its investing in the last two years. (PitchBook says NVentures engaged in 24 deals in 2024, compared to just 2 in 2022.)

In 2025, Nvidia has already participated in seven rounds.

Nvidia [has stated](#) that the goal of its corporate investing is to expand the AI ecosystem by backing startups it considers to be “game changers and market makers.”

Below is a list of startups that raised rounds exceeding \$100 million where Nvidia is a named participant since 2023, including new ones it has backed so far in 2025, organized from the highest amount to lowest raised in the round.

The billion-dollar-round club

OpenAI: Nvidia backed the ChatGPT maker for the first time in October, reportedly writing a [\\$100 million check](#) toward a colossal \$6.6 billion round that valued the company at \$157 billion. The

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chipmaker's investment was dwarfed by OpenAI's other backers, notably Thrive, which according to the New York Times invested \$1.3 billion.



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xAI: Nvidia participated in the \$6 billion round of Elon Musk's xAI. The deal revealed that not all of OpenAI's investors [followed its request](#) to refrain from backing any of its direct competitors. After investing in the ChatGPT maker in October, Nvidia joined xAI's cap table [a few months later](#).

Inflection: One of Nvidia's first significant AI investments also had one of the most unusual outcomes. In June 2023, Nvidia was one of several lead investors in Inflection's [\\$1.3 billion](#) round, a company founded by Mustafa Suleyman, who earlier founded DeepMind. Less than a year later, Microsoft hired Inflection AI's founders, [paying \\$620 million](#) for a non-exclusive technology license, leaving the company with a significantly diminished workforce and a less defined future.

Wayve: In May, Nvidia participated in a [\\$1.05 billion round](#) for the U.K.-based startup, which is developing a self-learning system for autonomous driving. The company is testing its vehicles in the U.K. and the San Francisco Bay Area.

Scale AI: In May 2024, Nvidia joined Accel and other tech giants Amazon and Meta to invest [\\$1 billion](#) in Scale AI, which provides data-labeling services to companies for training AI models. The round valued the San Francisco-based company at nearly \$14 billion.

The many-hundreds-of-millions-of-dollars club

Crusoe: A startup building data centers [reportedly](#) to be leased to Oracle, Microsoft, and OpenAI [raised \\$686 million](#) in late November, according to an SEC filing. The investment was led by Founders Fund, and the long list of other investors included Nvidia.

Figure AI: In February 2024, AI robotics startup Figure raised [a \\$675 million](#) Series B from Nvidia, OpenAI Startup Fund, Microsoft, and others. The round valued the company at \$2.6 billion.

Mistral AI: Nvidia invested in Mistral for the second time when the French-based large language model developer raised a \$640 million Series B at a [\\$6 billion valuation](#) in June.

Lambda: AI cloud provider Lambda, which provides services for model training, raised a [\\$480 million Series D](#) at a reported [\\$2.5 billion valuation](#) in February. The round was co-led by SGW and Andra Capital Lambda, and joined by Nvidia, ARK Invest, and others. A significant part of Lambda's business involves renting servers powered by Nvidia's GPUs.

Cohere: In June, Nvidia invested in Cohere's [\\$500 million round](#), a large language model provider serving enterprises. The chipmaker first backed the Toronto-based startup in 2023.

Perplexity: Nvidia first invested in Perplexity in November of 2023 and has participated in every subsequent round of the AI search engine startup, including the [\\$500 million](#) round in December, which values the company at \$9 billion, according to PitchBook data.

Poolside: In October, the AI coding assistant startup Poolside announced it raised [\\$500 million](#) led by Bain Capital Ventures. Nvidia participated in the round, which valued the AI startup at \$3 billion.

CoreWeave: Nvidia invested in the AI cloud computing provider in April 2023, when CoreWeave raised [\\$221 million](#) in funding. Since then, CoreWeave's valuation has jumped from about \$2 billion to [\\$19 billion](#), and the company has [filed for an IPO](#). CoreWeave allows its customers to rent Nvidia GPUs on an hourly basis.

Together AI: In February, Nvidia participated in the [\\$305 million Series B](#) of this company, which offers cloud-based infrastructure for building AI models. The round valued Together AI at \$3.3 billion and was co-led by Prosperity7, a Saudi Arabian venture firm, and General Catalyst. Nvidia backed the company [for the first time](#) in 2023.

Sakana AI: In September, Nvidia invested in the Japan-based startup, which trains low-cost generative AI models using small datasets. The startup raised a massive [Series A round of about \\$214 million](#) at a valuation of \$1.5 billion.

Imbue: The AI research lab that claims to be developing AI systems that can reason and code raised a [\\$200 million round](#) in September 2023

from investors, including Nvidia, Astera Institute, and former Cruise CEO Kyle Vogt.

Waabi: In June, the autonomous trucking startup raised a [\\$200 million Series B](#) round co-led by existing investors Uber and Khosla Ventures. Other investors included Nvidia, Volvo Group Venture Capital, and Porsche Automobil Holding SE.

Deals of over a \$100 million

Ayar Labs: In December, Nvidia invested in the [\\$155 million round](#) of Ayar Labs, a company developing optical interconnects to improve AI compute and power efficiency. This was the third time Nvidia backed the startup.

Kore.ai: The startup developing enterprise-focused AI chatbots raised [\\$150 million](#) in December of 2023. In addition to Nvidia, investors participating in the funding included FTV Capital, Vistara Growth, and Sweetwater Private Equity.

Sandbox AQ: In April, Nvidia, alongside Google, BNP Paribas, and others, invested [\\$150 million](#) in Sandbox AQ, a startup developing large quantitative models (LQMs) for handling complex numerical analysis and statistical calculations. The investment increased Sandbox AQ's Series E round to \$450 million and the company's valuation to \$5.75 billion.

Hippocratic AI: This startup, which is developing large language models for healthcare, announced in January that it raised a [\\$141 million Series B](#) at a valuation of \$1.64 billion led by Kleiner Perkins. Nvidia participated in the round, along with returning investors Andreessen Horowitz, General Catalyst, and others. The company claims that its AI solutions can handle non-diagnostic patient-facing tasks such as pre-operating procedures, remote patient monitoring, and appointment preparation.

Weka: In May, Nvidia invested in a [\\$140 million](#) round for AI-native data management platform Weka. The round valued the Silicon Valley company at \$1.6 billion.

Runway: In June of 2023, Runway, a startup building generative AI tools for multimedia content creators, raised a [\\$141 million Series C](#) extension from investors, including Nvidia, Google, and Salesforce.

Bright Machines: In June 2024, Nvidia participated in a [\\$126 million Series C](#) of Bright Machines, a smart robotics and AI-driven software startup.

Enfabrica: In September 2023, Nvidia invested in networking chips designer Enfabrica's [\\$125 million Series B](#). Although the startup raised another \$115 million in November, Nvidia didn't participate in the round.

Editor's note: A previous version of this story incorrectly stated that Nvidia is a backer of Safe Superintelligence and an investor in Vast Data's Series E round. Nvidia hasn't invested in Vast Data since the company's Series D.

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